



## How We Tested

CD-writing software should be easy enough for anyone to use, and also provide features for a power user. Also, the interface is of paramount importance, at least for the non-geeks amongst us. So we looked at how intuitive the application menus are, whether there are wizards that help you along, and so on. Then we looked for the different types of format supported, including video formats such as VCD and SVCD, and audio formats such as MP3, WMV and WAV. As far as data CDs were concerned, we looked at data backup capabilities, exact-copy creation capabilities, file browsing capabilities for when you're preparing your CDs for burning, and so on. We also checked how resource-hungry these software are,

both while they're idle, as well as while they're at work.

Almost all CD-burning software come bundled with some useful utilities, as a separate package or as an additional feature. These include CD label creators, basic audio and video editors, backup creators and others. We took these into account too.

Compatibility with CD-Writers is an important factor, since there is nothing more frustrating than getting a new CD-Writer and then finding out that your software won't work with it. And finally, we looked for extra features such as support for DVD writing, overburning, virus checking, bootable CD creation, multi-session CD writing and so on.

completing the writing process. This ensures error free burning. There's another feature called DJ Burn that is essentially a music format converter. It can convert your MP3 and WMA files to CDA files, which can then be used to write Audio CDs. There's also a bundled backup creation tool for an easy backup of your entire hard disk. The Microphone to CD feature allows recording sound directly from a microphone, or other source, onto CD. Finally, RecordNow MAX is the only utility that supports DDCD creation.

## Nero 6 Ultra Edition

Nero 6 is the latest offering from Ahead Software that sports a new interface—Nero Express. All wizards that were in the previous versions have been removed, but



*Nero 6 has a brand new, user-friendly interface*



*The Pinnacle start screen gives you access to every option you need*

feature is the ability to emulate CD-ROMs on your hard disk. This is popularly known as a virtual drive. It also has a ripping tool to save your Audio CDs onto your hard disk in the MP3, WMA, or WAV formats. A backup tool comes as a separate utility, though even Nero 6 and Record Max have this feature.

Instant CD/DVD supports packet-writing technology through a bundled utility called Instant Write. Using Instant Write, you can use your CD-RW drive as though it were a hard or floppy disk, by simply dragging and dropping a file that needs to be burnt onto the CD drive letter.

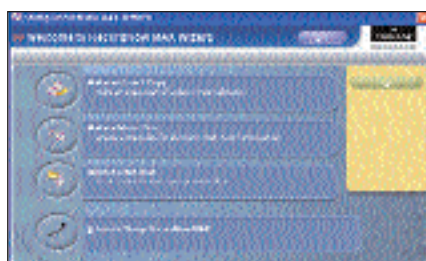
You can capture movies from DV camcorders, import photos from digital cameras, record sound from microphones and edit the resulting files before writing them onto CD.

Instant CD/DVD is perfect for home use and is good for professional users too, but the advanced features are not as comprehensive as that of Nero 6.

## RecordNow MAX 4.5

RecordNow MAX 4.5 from Stomp Inc. has a one-click installation process, which first-time users will love. Also, it has wizards for doing almost all the writing-related tasks. The file browser, however, doesn't support drag-and-drop functionality.

RecordNow MAX supports all major audio and video CD formats except SVCD, which is disappointing. Also, it cannot build ISO images, a feature found on all the other CD-writing software. A useful feature is disc spanning, that is, you can burn a large file onto multiple disks. This feature isn't present in Nero 6 and NTI CD



*RecordNow MAX has easy-to-use wizards, to make life easier*

Maker. You can also create bootable CDs from image files. Burning can be done from ISO and GI image files, but not from CUE files. RecordMAX has another feature called Drive Letter Access, which uses packet writing technology—you drag-and-drop files onto your CD-RW icon to burn files onto the disk. When you burn a CD, you can set an option to test the media before writing, and to verify the CD after

## What is Finalizing?

Finalizing is the process of closing a session on a disk. An open disk is one on which you can add data. A single-session disk has three areas: the lead-in, the program area and the lead-out. The lead-in contains the Table of Contents (ToC), the program area holds the data and the lead-out is used to pad the remaining portion of the disk with zeroes. When the session is closed, the ToC is written to the lead-in area, which enables all CD-ROMs and CD players to read the ToC and access the data. However, the disc cannot be opened again to write more data on it, and so the remaining space is wasted. However, if the data is written to the disc, and the session is not closed, the ToC is not written to the lead-in area; instead it is written to a separate area called the Program Memory Area (PMA). CD recorders are capable of looking into the PMA to find the ToC of the open session, and then continue to add more data in a new session. Thus, to make a disc multi-session, the burn process should not be finalized.

